



New Google Earth

Google unveiled a new version of Google Earth. Here are five new things you can do.
<http://dgit.in/newGEarth>



Pokemon creator

A neural network implementation can create some interesting Pokemon.
<http://dgit.in/Npokemon>

Origins

Plate. It was very similar to a dog tag with customer information embossed onto it. This was fed into an imprinter to record a transaction. Soon after, American Airlines introduced an Air Travel Card that would let you 'buy



A Charga Plate case.

now and pay later'. Within the next 15 years, the Air Travel Card became the first internationally valid charge card.

But most cards then were still limited to a particular vendor. You would need to carry one card for each vendor, or at least carry cash for anything beyond. The first roughly general purpose card was the Diners Club in 1950, which was soon followed by Carte Blanche and American Express. Over the next 20 years, Visa (initially BankAmericard) and MasterCard (then Mastercharge) would come to be. But all of this was still not computerised and a credit card transaction involved the following steps:

- Customer presents card.
- Merchant calls bank with card details.
- Bank calls credit card company with card details
- Credit card company gets employee to manually check details
- Transaction gets approved

Although computerisation did speed up the process to under one minute, it still took a while (the advent of the 21st century to be precise) for always connected payment terminals to become ubiquitous. Meanwhile, the magnetic strip was standardised for all cards – the same strip that you see today behind your card – around 1979. This was also the year when PoS terminals began to emerge across the U.S.

Online

Internet arrived on the scene early in the 1990s. Almost every sector benefited from the connectivity, including digital payments. Some of the most significant online payment systems started operations in the early 90s. In 1994, the Stanford Federal Credit Union was established. This was the first financial institution to offer online internet banking services to all members. However, these systems weren't even remotely user-friendly and required highly specialized knowledge in areas like encryption or data transfer protocol. Additionally, the systems weren't flexible enough to adapt to the rapidly changing volume of users and the nature of their transactions.

Initially, the main players in the e-payments arena were Millicent (founded in 1995), and ECash or CyberCoin (both in 1996). The majority of the first online services were using micropayment systems and almost all of them were trying to implement electronic cash alternatives (such as e-money, digital cash or tokens). Moreover, in 1994, Amazon was founded and Pizza Hut started accepting online food ordering. Pizza Hut's online food delivery system was one step ahead of all its competitors.

Getting pally with your payments

In 1999, PayPal began as a wireless payment service provider for the Palm Pilot. Back then it was launched by Confinity, a security software provider, which later merged with X.com, an online banking company founded by Elon Musk. Eventually, PayPal established a strong customer base on eBay, which prompted an eventual acquisition by eBay for 1.5 billion USD in 2002. At the time of the deal, 70% of all eBay auctions accepted PayPal payments,

and roughly 1 in 4 closed auction listings were transacted using the payment service.

Between its establishment and the eBay acquisition, PayPal had implemented a lot of innovative features around online payment – like HTML payment buttons, sending payments using email addresses, launching the reverse Turing test to reduce fraud and more. On the other hand, eBay's own response to these innovations was the creation of Billpoint, which was essentially a PayPal clone. On top of that, eBay took several measures to push people to use Billpoint, like offering free listing days for using Billpoint, cutting fees, mandating use of Billpoint for its Stores sites, rolling out a checkout button at the top of every listing that defaulted to Billpoint and more. And it wasn't just eBay – even banks were up in arms against PayPal, pursuing litigation to get PayPal classified as a bank or an unsecure service. It was sheer customer loyalty and popularity that pulled PayPal through this, which was followed by the acquisition.

In the subsequent years, PayPal made a lot of progress in terms of integration and adoption on eBay. But most of this progress was with the aim of improving the shopping experience on eBay. The core customers of the global payments ecosystem itself were



PayPal is quite popular for global payments

largely ignored. In 2014, Carl Icahn, an activist shareholder in PayPal, made a public statement asking eBay to spin-off PayPal as an independent company. Quoting Elon Musk, he said, "It doesn't make sense that a global payment system is a subsidiary of an